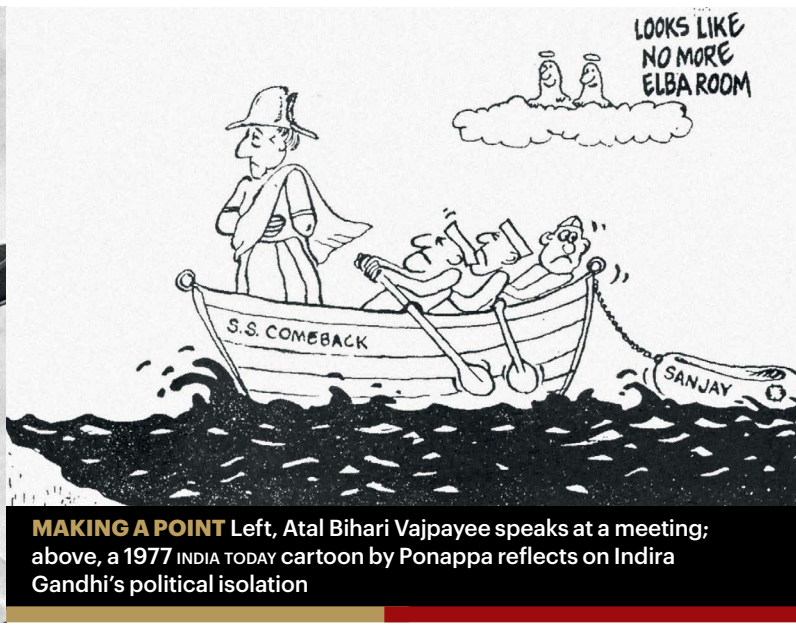
PEOPLE'S VERDICT Crowds in Delhi gather to watch Lok Sabha poll results being displayed on a scoreboard, March 1977

the North. The new PM, Morarji Desai, was another old foe, from the 'Syndicate' of the Congress right she thought she had vanquished long ago. The 1977 election felt something like a revolution at the time. Among its sideshows was the CPI(M) triumph in West Bengal, opening a 34-year streak of regional dominance that ended only in 2011. Of course, it was nothing like a revolution in the end. But it did offer a wormhole of insight to India's political future in the decades to come. The astonishing plasticity of political personalities and alliances first seen in the Janata victory still pulses in the coalitions of extremes that have since become a familiar feature of Indian elections. ■

INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES





MAKING A POINT Left, Atal Bihari Vajpayee speaks at a meeting; above, a 1977 INDIA TODAY cartoon by Ponappa reflects on Indira Gandhi's political isolation